



"Everybody is working very hard, and their intention is very good — that is a good sign. We have very motivated players," Jamil reassures.

Dynamic approach

By his critics, Jamil might be pigeon-holed as a defensive coach — parking the bus, waiting for a chance to hit against the run of play. But over the years, his designs reveal a more pragmatic approach.

Against possession-dominating sides, he tends to go with a heavy mid and low block (4-4-1-1 against FC Goa in a 3-1 win last season), while against long-ball playing teams, he prefers fluid counters, preferably a 4-3-3 (like in NorthEast United's wins against Bagan and Kerala Blasters FC in the 2020-21 season).

Last season, Jamshedpur scored multiple goals in 16 games under Jamil, the joint-most for any manager in that campaign, alongside Bagan's Jose Molina. However, his side conceded the second-most goals (43) in the regular season.

So how can we expect the Blue Tigers to play under him? "According to situations, we must be careful and

play as a team — that is the most important thing," Jamil says.

Jamil's penchant for forging a potent sense of unity within his teams is his biggest asset.

Squads assembled on shoestring budgets have overperformed under his tutelage, from Aizawl FC, which won the I-League in 2017, to NorthEast United and Jamshedpur, which reached the semifinals under him.

"He's the only Indian coach in the ISL for a reason. Though we weren't a big team, he ensured unity and took us deep into the tournament," adds VP Suhair, who played under Jamil at NorthEast and Jamshedpur.

"He gives players a lot of freedom. Even with a set plan, he allows us to express ourselves."

Though the CAFA Nations Cup will be his moment to break the ice, the

Straight into the fire: India's first assignments under Jamil will be against three strong teams — Tajikistan, Iran, and Afghanistan.

real litmus test awaits later, when India plays Singapore home and away in the Asian Cup qualifiers. But Jamil is not looking too far ahead.

"We must go step by step. This (Nations Cup) is a big challenge for us. We must get a positive result here," he says.

With a chunk of national team regulars out, Jamil finds himself in familiar territory — his back against the wall.

But he has, time and again, proven such predicaments to be his whetstone, and will hope to savour a similar challenge, clad in new robes, with the tricolour printed on them.

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